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An essay on the religion of the Bambara

Author(S): Dieterlen, Germaine, Wolf, Katia**Document Type:** Book Chapter**Original Page:** 157**Culture (OWC):** [Bambara \(FA08\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Western Africa**Field Date:** 1946-1949**Coverage Date:** Not Specified**Place Coverage:** Not Specified**Section Title(S):** Weapons And Tools

Every blacksmith is regarded as the holder of an excellent tere. He is well-intentioned, affable, and never hurts anyone. It is easy to make friends with him, to joke with him, even if one knows him but a short time. The senankuya relationships which he has with other Blacks also contribute to the cordiality of these ties.

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The good tere of the blacksmith is brought into play particularly at circumcision which is preferably entrusted to a Gwonna. Being circumcised by a blacksmith causes the wanzo to diminish rapidly, hastens the healing, and improves the tere. A blacksmith is reputed to have the power of transforming himself at will into an animal or a plant. In those places where hyenas are venerated as the animal protectors of a village (dasiri), they are always considered as the blacksmith's ancestors who have undergone metamorphosis. (1).

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The ritual paraphernalia now preserved in each village comprise models of all the tools manufactured by the blacksmiths since their first appearance.

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a. Wooden tools The craftsmen first used wood, gradually changing the shape of the objects. From a simple stick 116 (generally in sunzun) (2) or from a rough-hewn block, they gradually made more perfect tools, obtaining the shape desired by rubbing and polishing on rocks.

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The first weapon used in hunting was a throwing instrument in the shape of a boar-spear, the semenkala (from kala, handle, Fig. 9, A). Hewn from one piece, it comprised three distinct parts: (1) the bulonda; (2) the semenu; and (3) the koli (literally, hook). Men threw the object with all their strength at the pursued animal or else they dug into the earth where their prey was hiding with the pointed end (semena) which was often poisoned with a viper's venom. The weapon was the object of blood sacrifices carried out on the koli and destined to increase its strength.

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1. Particularly in the village of Konodimi, situated 21 km. to the southwest of Ségou.

2. Diospyros mespiliformis. The wood of this tree is very hard.

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